Nanette

By Hannah Gadsby

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I first started comedy over a decade ago. My first ever show was Classic New Gay Comic 101. I told lots of cool jokes about homophobia. Really solved that problem. Tick. I told a story about the time this young man had almost beaten me up because he thought I was *coming* on to his girlfriend. Actually, that bit was true, but . . . there was a twist. It happened late at night. The pub had closed, and I was waiting at the bus stop. It was the last bus home. And I was talking to a girl, and . . . you know, you could say flirting. I don't know. And out of nowhere, he just comes up and starts shoving me. And he goes, "Keep away from my girlfriend, you freak!" And she stepped in, going, "Whoa, stop it! It's a girl!" And he said "Oh, sorry. I'm so sorry. I don't hit women," he said. What a guy! "I don't hit women." How about you don't hit anyone? Good rule of thumb. And he goes, "Sorry, I got confused. I thought you were a faggot trying to *come* on to my girlfriend." Now I understand I have a responsibility to help lead people out of ignorance at every opportunity I can, but I left him there, people. Safety first.

INTRODUCTION

*Hannah Gadsby is an Australian comedian and writer who got started when she entered a standup comedy contest in 2006, performing for the very first time—and winning. But comedy rose to a new level when she used the stage to speak her truth in 2017 – a message that not only spoke to the LGBTQ community, but to **anyone** of difference and without social status.*

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The main part, the centerpiece, of that 1st show, was coming out to my family, and particularly my mom. Because my mom is very funny. She lives a comedy better than I can ever write it. Her response to me coming out, was this. "Oh, Hannah. Why did you have to tell me that? That's not something I need to know. I mean, what if I told you I was a murderer?" *(self-deprecating*

laugh) It's still funny. And it's a fair call. Murderer. (grows serious and sad) Murderer. Real jokes.

I do think I have to quit comedy though. I have been questioning . . . you know, this whole comedy thing. I don't feel very comfortable in it anymore. I built a career out of self-deprecating humor. That's what I've built my career on. And . . . I don't want to do that anymore. Because, do you understand . . . do you understand what self-deprecation means when it comes from somebody who already exists in the margins? It's not humility. It's humiliation. I put myself down in order to speak, in order to seek permission. . . to speak. And I simply will not do that anymore. Not to myself or anybody who identifies with me. And if that means that my comedy career is over, then so be it. I got a letter… on Facebook recently. And I say "letter," 'cause I'm very bold. Controversial. But I call it a letter, because it said, "Dear Hannah," comma, new line. . . "You owe it to your community to come out as transgender." All jokes aside . . . I don't identify as transgender. I mean, I'm clearly "gender not normal," but. . . I don't think even lesbian is the right identity fit for me, I really don't. I may as well come out now. I identify. . . as tired. I'm just tired. *(heavy sigh and then she jumps back in with some comedy)*

Did you know men and women have more in common than they don't? I don't think many people do know that because we always focus on the difference between men and women. You know what's weird? Pink headbands on bald babies! That's weird. Of course, I understand why parents do it. Clearly, they're sick and tired… of their beautiful baby girl… being mistaken for a boy baby because of the no hair situation. I understand that. How about this? How about we stop separating the children into opposing teams from day *one*? How about we give them, I dunno, seven to ten years to consider themselves on the same side?

I say we get rid of pink and give all babies **blue**. I've thought about this and it's not because blue is a masculine color. 'Cause that is false. I love that people go, "Blue, yeah, a very masculine color. Very reliable. Very rational color, blue. Yeah, you can trust blue. It's why we've got it on

flags. Lot of blue on flags." Blue, if anything, is a feminine color. It really is full of contradictions. You know, blue is on the cold end of the spectrum. But the hottest part of the flame? Blue. If you're feeling blue. . . you're sad. But optimism? Blue skies ahead! Make up your mind. A blueprint is a plan, but if something happens not on the plan, where does that come from? Out of the blue! Blue's a wonderful color to start life with. There's room for every kind of human in blue. *(Beat, change of subject and a more serious tone)*

I don't hate men, but I wonder how a man would feel if they'd lived my life. It was a man who sexually abused me when I was a child. It was a man who beat the shit out of me when I was 17, my prime. It was two men who raped me when I was barely in my twenties. Tell me why is that okay. Why was it okay to pick me off the pack like that and do that to me? It would have been more humane to just take me out to the back paddock and put a bullet in my head if it is that much of a crime to be different!

Laughter's the best medicine, they say. I don't. I reckon penicillin might give it the nudge. There is truth to it, though. Laughter is very good. When you laugh, you release tension. And when you hold tension in your body, it's not healthy -- psychologically or physically. That's why it's good to laugh. It's even better to laugh with other people. When you laugh, in a room full of people, you will release more tension because laughter is infectious.

Let me explain to you **what a joke is**. When you strip it back to its bare minimum, a joke is simply two things, it needs two things to work. A setup and a punch line. And it is essentially a question with a surprise answer. Right? I feel like, in a comedy show, there's no room for the best part of the story. . . which is the ending. You know, in order to finish on a laugh, you have to end with punch lines. Like, take my coming-out story, for example. The best part of that story is the fact that Mum and I have a wonderful relationship now. More than mother and daughter, we're friends, we trust each other. Look what I did to the room. No tension. You're just going, "Good *for* you. Got a good relationship with your mum, have you? Can you go back to the tension? That was hilarious."

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But, yeah, last year I was home for a week. Mum and I banter if you will. I say things like, "Mum, you made my life very difficult." And she'll go, "Yeah, well, I don't think I liked you very much." And we laugh! 'Cause you've got to laugh. *(long beat)* But not this day. She went quiet and got tense. What my mum eventually said to me is pretty much at the core of why I'm questioning comedy. She said to me, "The thing I regret is that I raised you as if you were straight. I didn't know any different. I am so sorry. I'm so sorry. I knew… well before you did… that your life was going to be so hard. I knew that, and I wanted it more than anything in the world not to be the case. And I know I made it worse, because I wanted you to change because I knew the world wouldn't." And I looked at my mum in that moment and thought, "How did that happen? How did my mum get to be the hero of my story?" She evolved. I didn't.

See I think part of my problem is comedy has suspended me in a perpetual state of adolescence. The way I've been telling that story is through jokes. And stories . . . unlike jokes, need three parts. A beginning, a middle, **and an end**. Jokes only need two parts. A beginning and a middle. And what I had done, with that comedy show about coming out, was I froze an incredibly formative experience at its trauma point and I sealed it off into jokes. And that story became a routine, and through repetition, that joke version fused with my actual memory of what happened. But unfortunately, that joke version was not nearly sophisticated enough to help me undo the damage done to me in reality. Punch lines need trauma because punch lines need tension, and tension feeds trauma.

Seventy percent of the people who raised me, who loved me, who I trusted, believed that homosexuality was a sin, that homosexuals were heinous, sub-human pedophiles. Seventy percent. By the time I identified as being gay, it was too late. I was already homophobic, and you do not get to just flick a switch on that. No, what you do is you internalize that homophobia and you learn to hate yourself. Hate yourself to the core. I sat soaking in shame. . . in the closet, for ten years. Because the closet can only stop you from being seen. It is not shame-proof.

When you soak a child in shame, they cannot develop the neurological pathways that carry carry thoughts of self-worth. They can't do that. Self-hatred is only ever a seed planted from outside in. But when you do that to a child, it becomes a weed so thick, and it grows so fast, the child doesn't know any different. It becomes as natural as gravity.

When I came out of the closet, I didn't have any jokes. The only thing I knew how to do was to be invisible and hate myself. It took me ten years to understand I was allowed to take up space in the world. But, by then, I'd sealed it off into jokes like it was no big deal. I need to tell my story properly. Because I paid dearly for a lesson that nobody seems to have wanted to learn. And this is bigger than homosexuality. This is about how we conduct debate in public about sensitive things. It's toxic, it's juvenile, it's destructive. We think it's more important to be right than it is to appeal to the humanity of people we disagree with.

Do you remember that story about that young man who almost beat me up? It was a very funny story. I made a lot of people laugh about his ignorance, and the reason I could do that is because I'm very good at this job. I am pretty good at controlling the tension. And I know how to balance that to get the laugh at the right place. But in order to balance the tension in the room with that story, I couldn't tell that story as it actually happened. Because I couldn't tell the part of the story where that man realized his mistake. And he came back. And he said, "Oh, no, I get it. You're a lady faggot. I'm allowed to beat the shit out of you," and he did! He beat the shit out of me and nobody stopped him. And I didn't . . . report that to the police, and I did not take myself to hospital, and I should have. And you know why I didn't? It's because I thought that was all I was worth. And that is what happens when you soak one child in shame and give permission to another to hate. And this tension, it's yours. I am not helping you anymore. You need to learn what this feels like because this . . . this tension is what not-normals carry inside all of the time because it is dangerous to be different!

I don't tell you this so you think of me as a victim. I am not a victim. I tell you this because my story has value. My story has value. To be rendered powerless does not destroy your humanity.

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Your resilience is your humanity. The only people who lose their humanity are those who believe they have the right to render another human being powerless. They are the weak. To yield and not break, that is incredible strength. Diversity is strength. Difference is a teacher. Fear difference, you learn nothing. What I would have done to have heard a story like mine. Not for blame. Not for reputation, not for money, not for power. But to feel less alone. To feel connected. I want my story. . . heard.

The damage done to me is real and debilitating. Laughter is not our medicine. Stories hold our cure. Laughter is just the honey that sweetens the medicine. I don't want to unite you with laughter or anger. I just needed my story heard, my story felt and understood by individuals with minds of their own. Because, like it or not, your story. . . is my story. And my story. . . is your story.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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